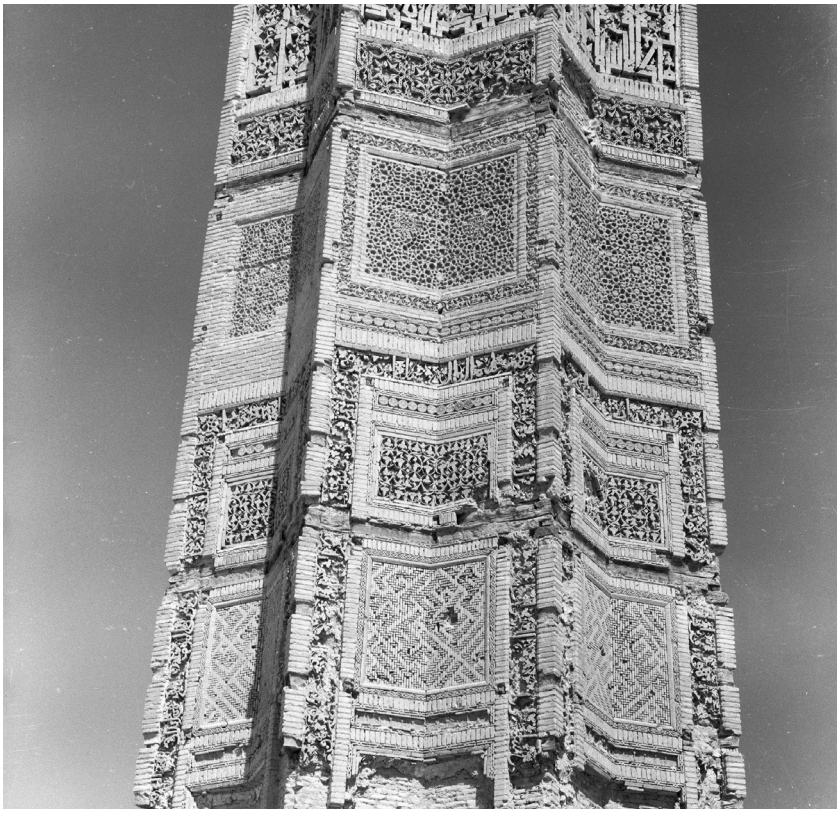


Figure 4.11 *Ghazni, minarets of Ghazni: minaret of Mas'ud III (1099–1115), middle section, detail. © Photograph Josephine Powell* c. *1960. Harvard Fine Arts Library, Special Collections.*

house had seen turbulent internal strife.[63] Mas'ud III's re-initiation of the profitable and propagandistically important Indian raids reclaimed some of the Ghaznavids' lost imperial glory, and also provided the sultan with the occasion to erect a towering structure commemorating what were essentially *his* victories.[64] The inscription of Surat al-Fath – unprecedented in its entirety of twenty-nine verses[65] – was in fluid cursive against a floral background, contained within a band meandering around quadrangular panels occupying the *minar*'s remaining surface areas (Figure 4.11). But equally notable was the royal appropriation of a visual device traditionally reserved for religious epigraphic content. Interlocking (*ma'aqali*) Kufic, ingeniously forming a grid of words, was not uncommon on funerary *stelae* and architectural surfaces (eleventh–twelfth centuries); but the content of these inscriptions had virtually always been religious in nature, such as the names of the first four *khalifa*s, or doxologies. However, the horizontal band of square panels near the base of the *minar* – its lower positioning making it more legible – was filled with the sultan's *kunya* and some of his